rather dramatically. ‘This was the one X factor that worried us. We were just not sure who had got this additional vote,’ a BJP strategist admitted to me later.

A senior journalist who met Sharad Pawar the day before the results said that the NCP leader was still hopeful of a hung Parliament. ‘I could sense he was still hoping that if the BJP ended up with around 200 to 220 seats, then smaller parties like his could play a major role in government formation,’ the journalist told me after his meeting with Pawar.

Some Congressmen were still living in denial. When I spoke to a Union minister and suggested that 300 seats for the NDA couldn’t be ruled out, he laughed: ‘You guys will never learn. You got it wrong in 2004 and 2009, you will be proven wrong yet again.’ A New York-based banker friend had a similar concern. ‘Waiting anxiously for your exit poll tomorrow night, Rajdeep. I just hope you guys won’t do a 2004 on us!’

Ah, 2004! The election that had virtually buried the science of psephology, or poll forecasting. No one had predicted that Vajpayee and Shining India would lose power and the Congress would form a coalition government. Frankly, by the last phase even then, there were signs that the NDA was on the decline, but no one wanted to stick their neck out and actually predict a Vajpayee defeat. Two states in particular—Andhra and Tamil Nadu—had swayed that verdict. This time, the locus of the conflict had shifted to the north. The final numbers in UP and Bihar would hold the key to whether India would really get its first single-party government since Rajiv Gandhi’s landslide in 1984.

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Exit polls are now an integral part of the great Indian election carnival. Many viewers are sceptical about the findings, but there are very few who don’t track the numbers. From Dalal Street to North Block, TV sets get switched on when the numbers are being announced.

My former boss at NDTV, Dr Prannoy Roy, is the guru of poll forecasting in India, building his reputation by getting the 1980 elections